

Wounded eagle is mending

Reward offered for info on shooter

By **BRUCE HENDERSON**

Staff Writer

Whoever shot the bald eagle that's now being treated at the Carolina Raptor Center could be in big trouble.

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service and the N.C. Falconer's Guild have offered a \$1,000 reward for information leading to the arrest and conviction of the shooter.

A conviction in the case, a federal offense, carries a fine of up to \$50,000 and a year in prison.

The eagle is being treated for a broken left wing. It has been gaining weight and is beginning to fly again. Rehabilitators hope it can be freed.

"We hope to be able to release the eagle in the next couple of weeks," rehabilitation director Mathias Engelmann said Friday. Once decimated by pesticides, bald eagles have rebounded in the Carolinas and elsewhere. They are now protected as a threatened species under the Endangered Species Act and by the Eagle Protection Act.

The eagle was found Jan. 10 near High Rock Lake, in Davidson County about 60 miles northeast of Charlotte. Falconer Bob Pendergrass, a raptor center volunteer, brought it to the center in Latta Plantation Park.

Wildlife officials say birds of prey, including eagles, were routinely shot in the past. The birds sometimes fed on chickens and other farm animals. Bald eagles, however, prefer fish.

Gunshot wounds were confirmed in more than 8 percent of birds the center treated in 1988. By 2000, that had fallen to 4.4 percent. The center credits education efforts for the decline.

The environmental education and rehabilitation center has treated more than 8,000 injured and orphaned birds of prey since 1980, last year returning 65 percent to the wild.



TODD SUMLIN/Staff

WANT TO HELP?

Anyone with information on the eagle's shooting should contact Special Agent Sandra Allred of the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service at (919) 856-4786 Ext. 34. For more information on the Carolina Raptor Center, visit www.BirdsOfPrey.org.

A \$1,000 reward is being offered for information leading to the arrest and conviction of the person responsible for shooting this bald eagle, which is being treated for a broken wing at the Carolina Raptor Center. The reward is offered by the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service and the N.C. Falconer's Guild.